A SURVEY REPORT ON

EMERGING TRENDS IN LOW-CODE APPLICATION DEVELOPMENT:

A STUDY OF ZOHO CREATOR

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ABSTRACT

A few years ago, low-code development was seen as a shortcut for small, simple internal tools. That is no longer true. By 2026, low-code has turned into a mainstream way for companies to build real, business-critical software, not just quick fixes. This report is a survey of where this shift stands today, using Zoho Creator as the main platform under study. Rather than treating Zoho Creator as an isolated tool, the report tries to place it within the bigger story of how application development is changing, faster AI assistance, built-in analytics, safer deployment pipelines, and tighter governance, are quickly becoming baseline expectations rather than nice-to-have extras. The report walks through what low-code actually means, unpacks Zoho Creator's own toolkit, and studies the specific trends reshaping the space this year. It also weighs Zoho Creator against a handful of other well-known platforms using a simple, visual comparison, before looking at how these tools are actually being applied in everyday business scenarios. A section on benefits and risks keeps the picture honest rather than one-sided, and the report closes by looking ahead at where this technology is likely headed next. Diagrams and charts are used throughout to make the ideas easier to follow at a glance, since a picture often explains a workflow faster than a paragraph can.

Keywords: Low-Code Development, Zoho Creator, AI-Assisted Development, Citizen Development, Workflow Automation, Application Governance

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1. Setting the Scene

1.1 What Do We Mean by “Low-Code”?

Every college student who has tried building even a basic website knows how much time goes into just wiring up the boring, repetitive parts, forms, buttons, database connections, before you even get to the interesting logic. Low-code development is essentially a way of skipping most of that repetitive wiring. Instead of typing it all out, a developer drags components onto a canvas, fills in a few settings, and lets the platform generate the underlying code. It is not the same as "no-code," which removes coding entirely, low-code still leaves a door open for custom scripts when the drag-and-drop tools cannot do something specific enough. That small bit of flexibility is exactly why low-code has been adopted so much more widely than pure no-code tools, it scales from a simple student project all the way up to a serious enterprise workflow.

1.2 Goals of This Survey

This report sets out to do five things: explain low-code development in plain terms, unpack what makes Zoho Creator tick as a platform, track the specific trends shaping the low-code space in 2026, place Zoho Creator next to a few of its competitors, and finally take an honest look at both the upside and the downside of relying on this kind of tool. The intent is not to promote any single platform, but to understand, as a student would, why this technology has become such a big deal in modern software development.

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2. Getting to Know Zoho Creator

2.1 Where It Fits in the Zoho Family

Zoho Creator did not appear out of nowhere. It is one product inside Zoho Corporation's much larger catalogue of business software, which also includes tools for accounting, sales, support, and HR. Being part of this bigger family matters more than it might first seem: an app built in Zoho Creator can quietly plug into Zoho CRM or Zoho Books without a developer having to build a custom connector from scratch. For any organisation already using Zoho's other products, this cuts out a whole layer of integration work that would otherwise eat up project time.

2.2 Toolkit at a Glance

Zoho Creator's toolbox covers most of what a small development team would otherwise need several separate tools for:

- **Visual Form & Page Builder:** lay out fields, buttons, and screens by simply dragging them into place.
- **Deluge Scripting:** a lightweight scripting language for the handful of situations where drag-and-drop logic is not enough.
- **Workflow Rules:** set conditions that trigger emails, record updates, or approvals automatically.
- **Cross-Platform Output:** one build runs on the web, Android, and iOS without separate versions.
- **Ready-Made App Templates:** a gallery of pre-built apps for common jobs like expense tracking or HR onboarding, so teams do not always start from a blank page.

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2.3 The Build Cycle, Visualized

It helps to picture how an idea actually turns into a working app on a platform like Zoho Creator. The diagram below breaks the process into five simple stages. None of these stages require writing a large codebase by hand, which is exactly what makes the whole cycle so much quicker than traditional development.



Fig 1: A simplified view of the low-code build cycle.

The first stage is simply describing what the app needs to do, sometimes literally by typing a plain-language prompt into Zia, Zoho Creator's AI assistant. From there, the app is shaped visually rather than through raw code, tested inside a separate, safe environment so nothing breaks for existing users, deployed once it is ready, and then kept under observation so that usage patterns and errors can be caught early. This loop repeats constantly. In fact, most teams do not treat a low-code app as "finished" the way a one-time class project might be, it keeps evolving in small steps as business needs shift.

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3. What's Changing in Low-Code Right Now

Looking across the industry in 2026, a handful of shifts stand out clearly, and Zoho Creator reflects nearly all of them.

3.1 AI Moves From Add-On to Default

A year or two ago, an AI assistant inside a low-code tool felt like a bonus feature. Now it is closer to an expectation. Instead of manually placing every field on a form, users increasingly just describe what they want in a sentence and let the AI put together a first draft. Zia, Zoho Creator's assistant, works this way, turning a written description into a working starting point that a user can then adjust.

3.2 Agents That Do, Not Just Answer

A more recent shift is the arrival of AI "agents" that do not just respond to a single question but carry out multi-step tasks on their own, for example, checking an approval queue, flagging anything unusual, and notifying the right person automatically. Zoho's broader platform strategy, referred to internally as AppOS, treats tools like Creator as building blocks that these agents can act upon under human-set rules. It is worth noting that this is still a young area, and not every agent project succeeds without careful setup and supervision.

3.3 Analytics Built Into the App Itself

Instead of exporting data into a separate analytics tool, modern low-code apps increasingly come with their own built-in charts, alerts, and even natural-language querying, so a user can simply ask a question about their data and get an answer without leaving the app. Zoho Creator has moved in this direction too, folding basic business intelligence features directly into the platform.

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3.4 Safer Testing Before Going Live

As low-code apps take on more serious, business-critical jobs, platforms have started borrowing habits from traditional software engineering, most notably, the idea of separate development, testing, and live environments. Zoho Creator now supports this kind of staged deployment, so a change can be tried out safely before it reaches the version everyone else is actually using.

3.5 Keeping an Eye on Who Builds What

When more people outside the IT department start building their own apps, someone still needs to keep track of what is being built and how secure it is. This is why governance features, access permissions, activity logs, backup options, are becoming a standard part of these platforms rather than an afterthought. It keeps the speed benefits of low-code without opening the door to careless, unmanaged "shadow" applications.

Putting all of this together, the chart below is a rough, qualitative snapshot of how Zoho Creator currently measures up across these very themes, based on the research gathered for this report.

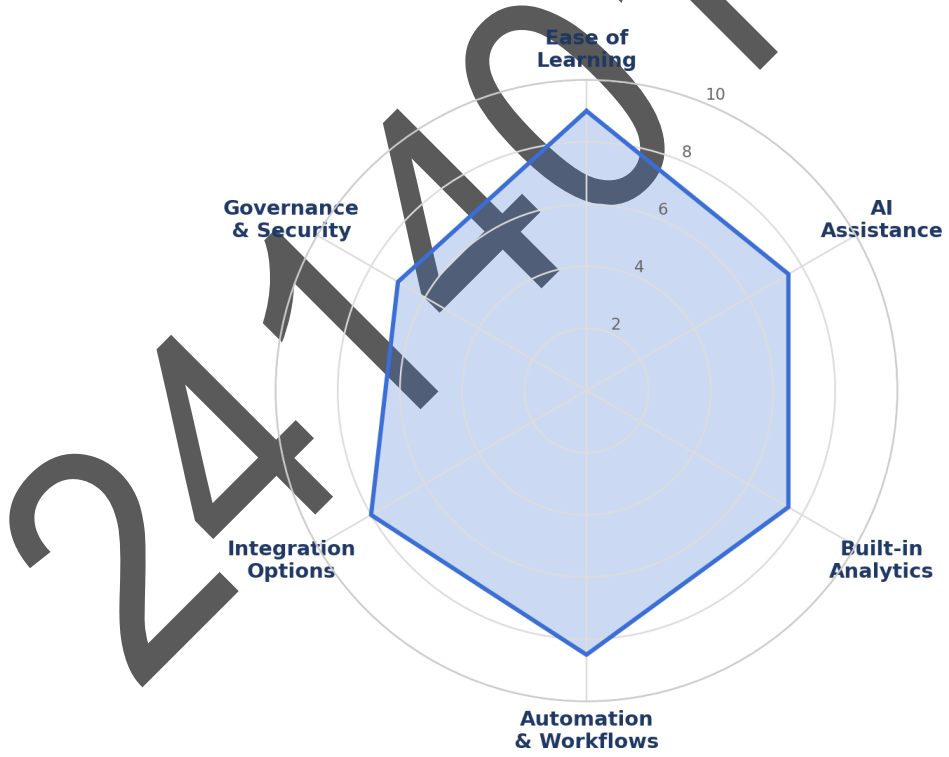


Fig 2: A qualitative capability snapshot of Zoho Creator (author's assessment, scale of 10).

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4. Sizing Up Zoho Creator's Strengths

Reading about features is one thing, but it helps to picture where a platform like Zoho Creator actually saves the most time in practice. Based on the kinds of apps it is typically used for, certain categories benefit far more than others simply because they rely so heavily on repetitive forms, approvals, and status tracking, exactly the parts that low-code tools are best at automating.

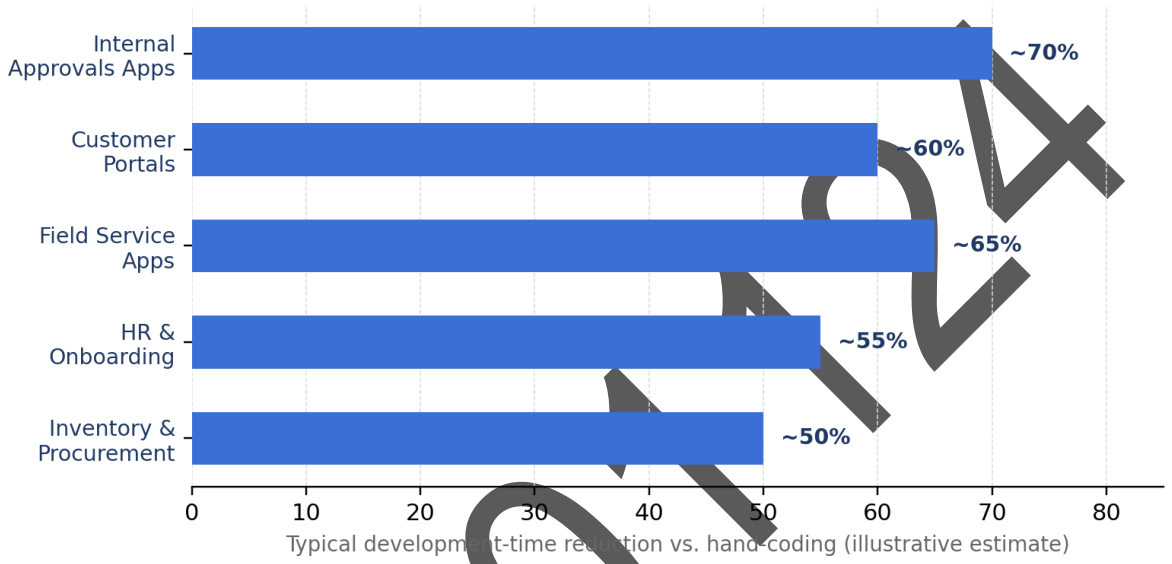


Fig 3: Where low-code development tends to save the most build time (illustrative estimate, not an official statistic).

Internal approval apps and customer-facing portals show up at the top of this picture because they usually follow a predictable pattern, collect some data, run it past a decision step, and notify someone, which is precisely the sort of logic that drag-and-drop workflow tools are built to handle. More unusual, highly specialised systems tend to save comparatively less time, since they lean more heavily on custom logic that still needs to be scripted by hand.

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5. How Zoho Creator Compares

Zoho Creator is not the only name in this space. A quick side-by-side against a few other well-known platforms helps explain where it tends to be picked, and where teams reach for something else instead.

Platform	Stands Out For	Tends to Suit
Zoho Creator	Fast setup, tight Zoho ecosystem fit	Small-to-mid teams, cross-department apps
Microsoft Power Apps	Native fit with Microsoft 365 & Azure	Organisations already on the Microsoft stack
Retool	Building internal tools over live databases fast	Engineering teams wiring up internal dashboards
OutSystems	Handling very large, complex systems reliably	Large enterprises with mission-critical apps
Mendix	Multi-channel apps built by bigger dev teams	Enterprises needing heavy customisation

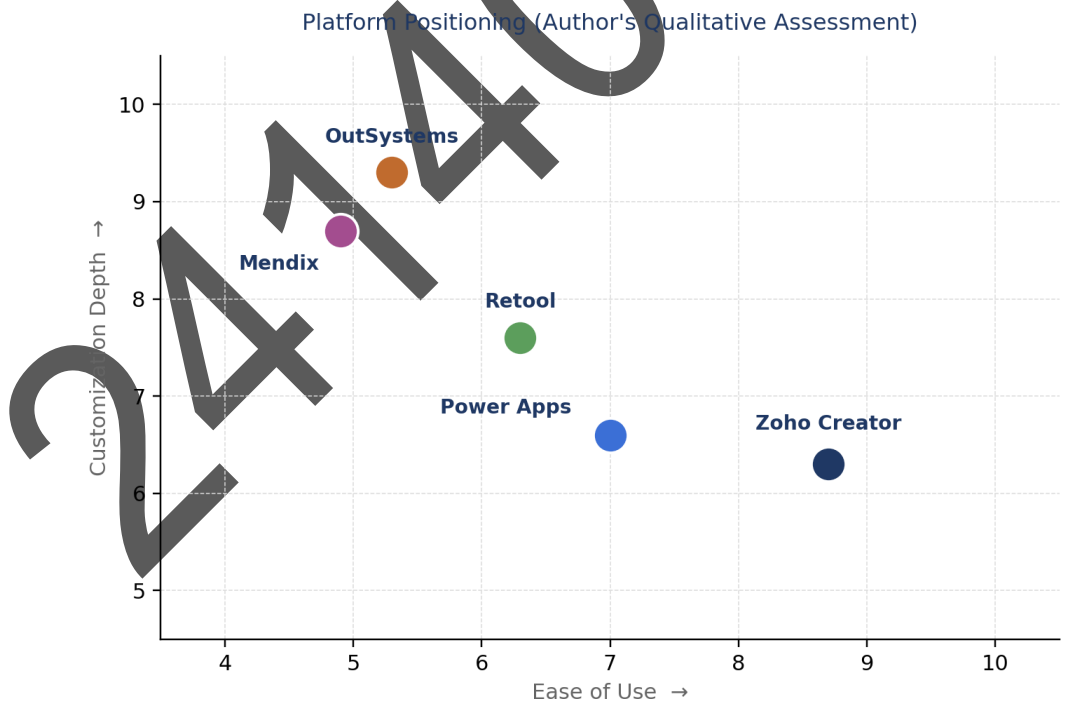


Fig 4: A rough positioning of these platforms by ease of use versus customization depth.

The pattern that comes through clearly is a trade-off: platforms that are easiest to pick up, like Zoho Creator, generally trade away some raw customization depth, while platforms built for deep customisation, like OutSystems or Mendix, ask for a steeper learning curve in return. Neither side is "better" in an absolute sense, it really depends on what a team actually needs to build.

6. Where These Apps Actually Show Up

Low-code platforms like Zoho Creator are used across a surprisingly wide range of everyday business situations. A few common examples:

- **Field Service Tracking:** assigning technicians to jobs, updating job status on the move, and capturing location data, even when the mobile signal is patchy.
- **Expense and Purchase Approvals:** routing spending requests through the right people automatically, cutting down on manual number-checking before audits.
- **Customer Self-Service Portals:** giving clients a place to check on their own requests or reports without pinging the support team every time.
- **Compliance Record-Keeping:** useful in tightly regulated fields like finance or healthcare, where records need to be checked against rules on an ongoing basis.
- **HR Onboarding and Leave Management:** replacing scattered spreadsheets and long email threads with one shared system that everyone actually uses.

What ties all of these together is a common shape: collect some information, apply a rule or two, and notify or update the right person. That repeating pattern is exactly why low-code tools fit so naturally into this kind of everyday business work.

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7. Weighing the Trade-Offs

7.1 What Works in Its Favour

- Apps typically come together in a fraction of the time compared to writing everything by hand.
- Non-programmers can build something genuinely useful without waiting on a scarce developer's time.
- One build runs across web and mobile, so there is no need to maintain separate versions.
- Built-in integrations mean less custom connector work between different business tools.
- Business teams and IT can work from the same visual model, which usually means fewer miscommunications.

7.2 Where It Falls Short

- Switching platforms later can be difficult once an organisation has built heavily on one system, a form of vendor lock-in.
- Very specific or performance-heavy requirements can outgrow what the visual tools alone can offer.
- Letting untrained users build apps without any oversight can quietly create security gaps, sometimes called shadow IT.
- Leaning too heavily on AI-generated logic without proper testing is a real risk, especially as autonomous "agent" features grow more common.
- Some routine, repetitive coding roles may shrink as more of that work gets automated away.

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8. Looking Down the Road

The direction of travel seems fairly settled at this point: low-code is moving from being a supporting tool to becoming a central part of how everyday business software gets built. Analysts covering this space widely expect most new business applications to lean on low-code platforms within the next few years, with much of that building work coming from people outside a formal IT role. For Zoho Creator specifically, the near-term path likely includes deeper AI agent capabilities under its AppOS strategy, stronger safeguards around those AI features so they do not repeat the failure patterns seen in poorly supervised early agent projects, and an analytics engine that surfaces insights with even less manual digging. Across the industry more broadly, the line between "low-code" and "AI-driven development" looks set to blur further, describing an app to an AI assistant may soon feel like the normal starting point rather than a novelty.

9. Closing Thoughts

Working through this survey made it clear that low-code development, and Zoho Creator in particular, is not just about skipping code for its own sake. It is about reshaping who gets to build software and how quickly an idea can turn into something usable. Zoho Creator's real strength lies in how approachable it is, paired with just enough depth, through Deluge scripting, workflow automation, and now AI assistance, to handle genuinely useful business problems. It is not the right fit for every situation, especially where deep customisation or massive scale is the priority, but for the everyday apps that keep a business running day to day, it offers a fast, sensible, and increasingly intelligent way to get there. If the trends covered in this report continue at their current pace, the distinction between "writing an app" and "describing an app" may not last much longer.

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